

US Branch Cultural Leadership Scenario Cards

Role-play packet for directness, pushback, meeting control, feedback, and repair

Audience: instructors, coaches, peer practice groups, and advanced manager cohorts

Focus: cultural leadership, pragmatic communication, meeting behavior, conflict repair, and confident pushback in US branch environments.

Designed for advanced Japanese and Chinese managers who already have functional English and need a clearer map of American workplace expectations.

Teaching stance: culture is a pattern, not a prison. The materials describe common workplace expectations and perception gaps, then ask learners to observe the actual company, team, role, and person in front of them.

How to Run the Scenario Cards

1. Use groups of three: manager, US colleague, observer.
2. Give the manager 90 seconds to prepare and four minutes to act.
3. The US colleague should be direct and realistic, not cartoonishly rude.
4. The observer scores: business clarity, pushback handling, process control, dignity, and decision close.
5. After the role-play, replay the hardest 30 seconds with a stronger manager response.

Facilitator guardrail

Do not reward aggression for its own sake. The target is calm authority, useful challenge, and relationship-safe directness.

1. The Blunt Engineer

Context

A senior engineer says, 'No, that architecture is a bad idea,' during your project review.

Manager card	US colleague card
You are the branch manager. You feel publicly embarrassed, but the engineer may have a real technical concern. Keep authority, extract the risk, and close the discussion.	You are the engineer. You are not trying to insult the manager; you believe the proposal could fail under load. You speak quickly and directly.

Observer focus

Watch whether the manager separates tone from content, asks for evidence, and sets a process boundary if needed.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

A senior engineer says, 'No, that architecture is a bad idea,' during your project review.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You are the engineer. You are not trying to insult the manager; you believe the proposal could fail under load. You speak quickly and directly.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	I hear the concern. What failure mode do you see under load?
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.

Option	Phrase
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	You are the branch manager. You feel publicly embarrassed, but the engineer may have a real technical concern. Keep authority, extract the risk, and close the discussion.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

2. Headquarters Already Decided

Context

US staff suspect the meeting is fake because headquarters has already chosen the plan.

Manager card	US colleague card
Explain what is fixed, what is open, and where local input can still shape execution.	Push hard: 'Do we actually have any say, or is this just theater?'

Observer focus

Listen for honesty about constraints and a credible invitation for input.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

US staff suspect the meeting is fake because headquarters has already chosen the plan.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	Push hard: 'Do we actually have any say, or is this just theater?'
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	Here is what is fixed. Here is where your input can still change the execution.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Explain what is fixed, what is open, and where local input can still shape execution.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

3. The Deadline Refusal

Context

A team lead says a headquarters deadline is impossible and refuses to commit.

Manager card	US colleague card
Push for ownership without ignoring reality. Ask for options and tradeoffs.	Do not accept vague optimism. You need scope removed or more people.

Observer focus

Track whether the conversation reaches an action plan rather than a status argument.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

A team lead says a headquarters deadline is impossible and refuses to commit.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	Do not accept vague optimism. You need scope removed or more people.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	I cannot commit to that date without a scope or staffing option we can support.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Push for ownership without ignoring reality. Ask for options and tradeoffs.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

4. Silence After the Question

Context

You ask for objections. The room is quiet. Two days later, an employee says everyone knew the plan had problems.

Manager card	US colleague card
Reset the norm. Make silence less comfortable than useful dissent.	You stayed quiet because you did not want to embarrass the manager.

Observer focus

Notice whether the manager creates a specific structure for dissent.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

You ask for objections. The room is quiet. Two days later, an employee says everyone knew the plan had problems.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You stayed quiet because you did not want to embarrass the manager.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	I want one specific objection from each function before we close the discussion.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Reset the norm. Make silence less comfortable than useful dissent.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

5. Public Performance Challenge

Context

An employee challenges your data in front of a visiting executive.

Manager card	US colleague card
Respond without defensiveness. Decide whether to answer now, park it, or follow up.	You believe the data is wrong and the executive needs to know before approving budget.

Observer focus

Watch for face-saving, factual clarity, and executive confidence.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

An employee challenges your data in front of a visiting executive.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You believe the data is wrong and the executive needs to know before approving budget.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	Let us check the data source now; if it is wrong, we will correct the record before approval.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Respond without defensiveness. Decide whether to answer now, park it, or follow up.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

6. The Overly Friendly Employee

Context

An employee uses first names, jokes in meetings, and challenges your priorities casually.

Manager card	US colleague card
Decide what is cultural style and what is a performance issue. Set expectations only where necessary.	You think informality builds trust and speed.

Observer focus

Check whether the manager avoids turning style discomfort into discipline.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

An employee uses first names, jokes in meetings, and challenges your priorities casually.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You think informality builds trust and speed.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	Informality is not the issue. I need us to agree on the decision and follow-through.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Decide what is cultural style and what is a performance issue. Set expectations only where necessary.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

7. The Hidden No

Context

You told a US partner, 'We will consider it,' meaning no. They announced the idea as likely approved.

Manager card	US colleague card
Repair the misunderstanding and replace indirect refusal with clear conditions.	You believed 'consider' meant there was a real chance.

Observer focus

Listen for a clear no, reason, and possible alternative.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

You told a US partner, 'We will consider it,' meaning no. They announced the idea as likely approved.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You believed 'consider' meant there was a real chance.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	I am not approving this as proposed. Here are the conditions that would change that answer.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Repair the misunderstanding and replace indirect refusal with clear conditions.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

8. Interrupted Three Times

Context

A strong talker interrupts a quieter analyst three times.

Manager card

Protect the analyst's floor without shaming the interrupter.

US colleague card

You are excited and believe your points are urgent.

Observer focus

Watch for process control and dignity for both people.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

A strong talker interrupts a quieter analyst three times.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You are excited and believe your points are urgent.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	Let her finish the point. Then I will come back to your concern.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.

Option	Phrase
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Protect the analyst's floor without shaming the interrupter.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

9. The Escalating Tone

Context

Debate moves from 'The plan has a gap' to 'You do not understand the customer.'

Manager card	US colleague card
Stop the personal attack and redirect to business evidence.	You are frustrated because the same issue has appeared before.

Observer focus

Mark the exact moment when manager intervention is required.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

Debate moves from 'The plan has a gap' to 'You do not understand the customer.'

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You are frustrated because the same issue has appeared before.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	That wording is personal. Restate the concern as a customer, cost, quality, or timing risk.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.

Option	Phrase
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Stop the personal attack and redirect to business evidence.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

10. Quality vs Speed

Context

Headquarters wants quality review; local sales wants launch speed.

Manager card	US colleague card
Translate both values into business risk and make a temporary decision.	Push for launch: 'The market will not wait for perfect.'

Observer focus

Look for pilot thinking, risk ownership, and review date.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

Headquarters wants quality review; local sales wants launch speed.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	Push for launch: 'The market will not wait for perfect.'
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	We can consider a controlled pilot, with a named risk owner and review date.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Translate both values into business risk and make a temporary decision.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

11. Performance Feedback Surprise

Context

An employee is shocked by negative feedback in the annual review.

Manager card	US colleague card
Explain the issue directly, but acknowledge if expectations were not made clear earlier.	You feel blindsided and unfairly judged.

Observer focus

Check for observable examples, fairness, and next steps.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

An employee is shocked by negative feedback in the annual review.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You feel blindsided and unfairly judged.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	I should have raised this earlier. Here are the observed examples and the expectation going forward.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Explain the issue directly, but acknowledge if expectations were not made clear earlier.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

12. The Seniority Mismatch

Context

A younger US specialist contradicts an older visiting executive from Asia.

Manager card	US colleague card
Protect the executive's dignity while preserving the specialist's useful information.	You are the specialist. You believe the executive is missing a local regulatory detail.

Observer focus

Notice whether expertise and hierarchy both receive respect.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

A younger US specialist contradicts an older visiting executive from Asia.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You are the specialist. You believe the executive is missing a local regulatory detail.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	Let us test the regulatory detail on its merits, then decide how it affects the plan.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Protect the executive's dignity while preserving the specialist's useful information.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

13. Email That Sounds Angry

Context

You receive a short email: 'This does not address my concern. Fix by EOD.'

Manager card	US colleague card
Decide whether to answer by email, call, or clarify. Do not assume hostility too quickly.	You are under customer pressure and think your email is efficient, not rude.

Observer focus

Evaluate whether the manager chooses the right channel.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

You receive a short email: 'This does not address my concern. Fix by EOD.'

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You are under customer pressure and think your email is efficient, not rude.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	Before I infer tone from the email, I want to clarify the customer impact and deadline.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Decide whether to answer by email, call, or clarify. Do not assume hostility too quickly.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

14. Local Autonomy

Context

US employees want to adapt a process that headquarters standardized globally.

Manager card	US colleague card
Define what can be localized and what cannot.	You think the global process ignores US customers.

Observer focus

Listen for fixed/open categories and escalation path.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

US employees want to adapt a process that headquarters standardized globally.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You think the global process ignores US customers.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	The global control is fixed; the local workflow is open if it protects the same outcome.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.

Option	Phrase
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Define what can be localized and what cannot.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

15. The After-Hours Request

Context

A manager from headquarters expects weekend responses; US staff object.

Manager card	US colleague card
Set urgency standards and protect critical work without creating constant availability.	You need predictable personal time and dislike vague urgency.

Observer focus

Check whether the policy is clear, fair, and business-realistic.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

A manager from headquarters expects weekend responses; US staff object.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You need predictable personal time and dislike vague urgency.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	Let us define what counts as urgent, who is on call, and what can wait until business hours.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Set urgency standards and protect critical work without creating constant availability.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

16. The Strong Candidate

Context

A candidate in an interview speaks confidently and asks pointed questions.

Manager card	US colleague card
Distinguish confidence from arrogance and evaluate job-relevant evidence.	You are the candidate. You expect the interview to be a two-way evaluation.

Observer focus

Look for bias control and evidence-based evaluation.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

A candidate in an interview speaks confidently and asks pointed questions.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You are the candidate. You expect the interview to be a two-way evaluation.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	Confidence is useful evidence only when it is paired with relevant examples and results.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Distinguish confidence from arrogance and evaluate job-relevant evidence.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

17. Repair After a Bad Meeting

Context

You shut down debate too quickly yesterday. A key employee is now quiet.

Manager card	US colleague card
Repair without surrendering authority.	You felt dismissed and are not sure it is worth speaking up again.

Observer focus

Listen for ownership, invitation, and specific future process.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

You shut down debate too quickly yesterday. A key employee is now quiet.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	You felt dismissed and are not sure it is worth speaking up again.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	I shut down the discussion too quickly. I want to hear the concern and set a better process next time.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
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C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.

Option	Phrase
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Repair without surrendering authority.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

18. Capstone: The Product Launch Decision

Context

Engineering, sales, headquarters, and finance disagree about launch timing.

Manager card	US colleague card
Lead a 20-minute meeting. Surface objections, control interruptions, decide next action, and assign owners.	Choose a function and push strongly for your priority.

Observer focus

Score leadership clarity, pushback handling, decision close, and relationship safety.

Debrief questions

- What did the manager correctly decode?
- Where did the manager need more confidence or more restraint?
- What phrase changed the emotional direction of the exchange?
- What should be documented or followed up after this situation?

Three-step leadership decision practice

Situation

Engineering, sales, headquarters, and finance disagree about launch timing.

Speaker	Line
US colleague	Choose a function and push strongly for your priority.
Manager	_____

1. Choose the strongest manager line

Choose the response that preserves useful directness while setting a clear leadership boundary.

Option	Phrase
A	We will take objections for ten minutes, then choose an option, owner, and review date.
B	We have discussed this long enough. Please stop challenging the decision.
C	I will decide later; for now, let us avoid the difficult part of the discussion.
D	Your tone is the main issue, so the business concern does not need to be examined.

2. Diagnose the cultural risk

Choose the interpretation that avoids turning a style difference into a personal judgment.

Option	Phrase
A	Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.
B	Assume direct disagreement proves disrespect for the manager.

Option	Phrase
C	Treat silence as agreement and move on without inviting a specific concern.
D	Use hierarchy to end the discussion before the evidence is visible.

3. Select the next leadership move

Choose the next step that turns the exchange into a fair, observable management process.

Option	Phrase
A	Lead a 20-minute meeting. Surface objections, control interruptions, decide next action, and assign owners.
B	Close the issue without naming what is fixed, open, risky, or owned.
C	Make a personal judgment about the colleague rather than testing the work concern.
D	Delay the discussion indefinitely and leave expectations unclear.

Answer Key and Rationale

Check each answer after completing the dialogue. The rationale identifies the leadership principle behind the selected phrase.

1. The Blunt Engineer - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I hear the concern. What failure mode do you see under load?	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

1. The Blunt Engineer - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

1. The Blunt Engineer - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. You are the branch manager. You feel publicly embarrassed, but the engineer may have a real technical concern. Keep authority, extract the risk, and close the discussion.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

2. Headquarters Already Decided - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Here is what is fixed. Here is where your input can still change the execution.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

2. Headquarters Already Decided - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

2. Headquarters Already Decided - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Explain what is fixed, what is open, and where local input can still shape execution.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

3. The Deadline Refusal - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I cannot commit to that date without a scope or staffing option we can support.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

3. The Deadline Refusal - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

3. The Deadline Refusal - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Push for ownership without ignoring reality. Ask for options and tradeoffs.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

4. Silence After the Question - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I want one specific objection from each function before we close the discussion.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

4. Silence After the Question - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

4. Silence After the Question - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Reset the norm. Make silence less comfortable than useful dissent.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

5. Public Performance Challenge - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Let us check the data source now; if it is wrong, we will correct the record before approval.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

5. Public Performance Challenge - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

5. Public Performance Challenge - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Respond without defensiveness. Decide whether to answer now, park it, or follow up.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

6. The Overly Friendly Employee - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Informality is not the issue. I need us to agree on the decision and follow-through.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

6. The Overly Friendly Employee - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

6. The Overly Friendly Employee - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Decide what is cultural style and what is a performance issue. Set expectations only where necessary.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

7. The Hidden No - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I am not approving this as proposed. Here are the conditions that would change that answer.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

7. The Hidden No - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

7. The Hidden No - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Repair the misunderstanding and replace indirect refusal with clear conditions.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

8. Interrupted Three Times - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Let her finish the point. Then I will come back to your concern.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

8. Interrupted Three Times - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

8. Interrupted Three Times - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Protect the analyst's floor without shaming the interrupter.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

9. The Escalating Tone - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. That wording is personal. Restate the concern as a customer, cost, quality, or timing risk.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

9. The Escalating Tone - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

9. The Escalating Tone - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Stop the personal attack and redirect to business evidence.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

10. Quality vs Speed - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. We can consider a controlled pilot, with a named risk owner and review date.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

10. Quality vs Speed - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

10. Quality vs Speed - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Translate both values into business risk and make a temporary decision.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

11. Performance Feedback Surprise - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I should have raised this earlier. Here are the observed examples and the expectation going forward.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

11. Performance Feedback Surprise - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

11. Performance Feedback Surprise - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Explain the issue directly, but acknowledge if expectations were not made clear earlier.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

12. The Seniority Mismatch - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Let us test the regulatory detail on its merits, then decide how it affects the plan.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

12. The Seniority Mismatch - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

12. The Seniority Mismatch - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Protect the executive's dignity while preserving the specialist's useful information.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

13. Email That Sounds Angry - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Before I infer tone from the email, I want to clarify the customer impact and deadline.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

13. Email That Sounds Angry - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

13. Email That Sounds Angry - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Decide whether to answer by email, call, or clarify. Do not assume hostility too quickly.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

14. Local Autonomy - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. The global control is fixed; the local workflow is open if it protects the same outcome.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

14. Local Autonomy - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

14. Local Autonomy - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Define what can be localized and what cannot.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

15. The After-Hours Request - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Let us define what counts as urgent, who is on call, and what can wait until business hours.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

15. The After-Hours Request - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

15. The After-Hours Request - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Set urgency standards and protect critical work without creating constant availability.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

16. The Strong Candidate - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Confidence is useful evidence only when it is paired with relevant examples and results.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

16. The Strong Candidate - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

16. The Strong Candidate - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Distinguish confidence from arrogance and evaluate job-relevant evidence.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

17. Repair After a Bad Meeting - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I shut down the discussion too quickly. I want to hear the concern and set a better process next time.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

17. Repair After a Bad Meeting - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

17. Repair After a Bad Meeting - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Repair without surrendering authority.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.

18. Capstone: The Product Launch Decision - Strongest manager line

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. We will take objections for ten minutes, then choose an option, owner, and review date.	The strongest line keeps the conversation concrete: it identifies a process, evidence, condition, or decision boundary instead of treating directness itself as disloyalty.

18. Capstone: The Product Launch Decision - Cultural diagnosis

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Separate the colleague's communication style from the underlying work concern, then decide whether a process boundary is needed.	This interpretation makes room for the possibility that an intense, direct, informal, or quiet behavior has a legitimate business meaning. It still leaves the manager free to set a boundary when the process or wording becomes harmful.

18. Capstone: The Product Launch Decision - Next leadership move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Lead a 20-minute meeting. Surface objections, control interruptions, decide next action, and assign owners.	The manager's next move should make the process visible: clarify the facts, protect dignity, name the decision rights, and specify what will happen next.